

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

US Army is said to put soldiers on standby

Minneapolis mayor opposes deployment amid protests

By Konstantin Toropin
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The Pentagon has ordered about 1,500 active-duty soldiers to be ready in case of a possible deployment to Minnesota, where federal authorities have been conducting a massive immigration enforcement operation, two defense officials said Sunday.

The officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military plans, said two infantry battalions of the Army's 11th Airborne Division have been given prepare-to-deploy orders. The unit is based in Alaska, specializing in operating in arctic conditions.

One defense official said the troops are standing by to deploy to Minnesota should President Donald Trump invoke the Insurrection Act, a rarely used 19th century law that would allow him to employ active duty troops as law enforcement.

The move comes just days after Trump threatened to do just that to quell protests against his administration's immigration crackdown.

In an emailed statement, Pentagon chief spokesman Sean Parnell did not deny the orders were issued and said the military "is always prepared to execute the orders of the Commander-in-Chief if called upon."

The mayor of Minneapolis said Sunday that sending active duty soldiers into Minnesota to help with an immigration crackdown is a ridiculous and unconstitutional idea as he urged protesters to remain peaceful so the president won't

Turn to Minnesota, Page 4

Trial to open window into life of alleged conman

Man faces extortion charges related to restaurateur's beating

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Sometimes he introduced himself as the son of infamous Colombian drug lord Pablo Escobar, or claimed to be a made man in the mafia, federal prosecutors say.

To many, he seemed like a charming and successful businessman, someone who could walk into any high-end steakhouse in downtown Chicago and know everybody who was anybody. He wined and dined sophisticated women, palled around with Chicago cops, and told people he had a vast portfolio of businesses, real estate and restaurants, according to prosecutors.

But in reality, prosecutors say, Jawad Fakroune is a convicted con man who used fake identities, false promises and, at times, threats and violence to further his criminal schemes and lead a lavish lifestyle.

The facade began to crumble in spectacular fashion in November 2024, when Fakroune allegedly beat up a well-known Chicago-area restaurateur over a purported \$1.5 million debt and threatened to kill him and his family, according to court records.

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NFC DIVISIONAL PLAYOFFS



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SHOW'S OVER

Bears quarterback Caleb Williams leaves the field after the team's 20-17 overtime loss to the Los Angeles Rams on Sunday in the NFC divisional playoff game at Soldier Field. The Bears lost despite an exhilarating last-minute touchdown, thrown by Williams and caught by tight end Cole Kmet, that tied the game and forced it into overtime. **Coverage in Chicago Sports**

Bears fans pledge undying support

The Super Bowl, the end of the world, even Indiana. 'We'll follow them there, everywhere'

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

The devotion of longtime Chicago Bears fans was on full display Sunday afternoon as they steeled their nerves ahead of a decisive playoff game against the Los Angeles Rams and celebrated a surprising winning season outside Soldier Field.

Wearing a furry hat with a fake bear head that rested on top of his own, Ridvan Alka beamed with pride at his cargo van wrapped in the team's iconic navy blue and orange. Inside, the vehicle is outfitted with a full-size bar and a flat-screen television that pulls down from the ceiling. It can still fit 12 people.

Though the Des Plaines family has been tailgating home games for decades, it was only this season that Alka debuted the custom van — and it felt like "the right year," he said with a laugh. "We're going to the Super Bowl!"

When there is no home game, they have road-tripped to every away game, even those out west: "Vegas, San Francisco, Washington, you name it," said Alka. "We're there."



Ridvan Alka, left, laughs as he tailgates with friends Sunday outside Soldier Field. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE**

It's a sentiment that extends to whatever the future portends for the team's home base, which has been in limbo since the franchise began planning for a new stadium three years ago. The move has stirred up conflicting feelings among Chicagoans and suburbanites alike. Arlington Heights officials are pushing Illinois lawmakers to help the suburb land an agreement for a new

stadium, while Indiana lawmakers introduced a bill to draw the team across the state border.

"We'll follow them," Alka said matter-of-factly. He took a beat to join other tailgaters in booing and heckling a pair of Los Angeles Rams fans who walked by. "We'll follow them there, everywhere. We drove all the way to San Francisco. You think I won't drive to Indiana?"

More fans on Sunday echoed a similar passion. They'd follow the Bears to the end of the world but preferably to the Super Bowl.

Michael Dibartolomeo has been flying from Dallas to Chicago for every Bears home game over the past two decades. On Sunday, he donned a long, neon orange beard, blue face paint and an

Turn to Fans, Page 4

Speaking up for 316,000 students

CPS honorary student board member reflects on her tenure so far

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

Destiny Singleton stood inside a Garfield Park church last November. Every seat was filled for the community event, but her voice was measured as she spoke into the microphone. The question put to her was simple: What would you change about your school?

"One thing I wish that could be improved is how admin treats the

student voice," Singleton told the crowd, her neon blue braids draping her shoulders.

Singleton, a senior at Ogden International High School, is used to speaking up. As the honorary student member of the Chicago Board of Education, she represents 316,000 students across the district.

At 17, she has been outspoken about the strengths and shortcomings of Chicago Public Schools. Halfway through her tenure, she has already witnessed a series of historic moments for

Turn to Student, Page 4



Destiny Singleton, an honorary student member of the Chicago Board of Education, attends Ogden International High School in Chicago. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

INSIDE

Worship ceremony honors MLK

Several hundred people gathered at a Grand Crossing church on Sunday to honor the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Deportation data spotlights spike

To deliver on President Donald Trump's promise to deport millions of people, his administration is pushing new approaches. **Nation & World**